

What is the Best Kind of Yoga for Beginners?

The activity called yoga means different things to different people around the world. The word itself comes from the Sanskrit language and means “union.”

For some, yoga is an exercise centered on mindful breathing and slow movement. For others, it is a series of difficult body movements and positioning designed to improve health and fitness. Still others consider yoga a spiritual exercise. And there are many people for whom yoga is a combination of all or some of these things.

So, yoga takes many different forms around the world.

All kinds of yoga involve positions known as poses (asanas). But the positions and training can differ even under yoga methods, or styles, of the same name, including hatha, vinyasa, Iyengar and others.

So, what is the best kind of yoga training for a beginner?

“The best is the one that works for you,” said Tim Senesi, who has been teaching yoga in Orange County, California, for 22 years. “There are many different paths leading toward the same aim,” he added.

FILE - Women attend a yoga master class at Shogun sports center in Kyiv, Ukraine on Nov. 29, 2024. (AP Photo/Evgeniy Maloletka)

The hatha/yin yoga styles

Hatha, meaning “force,” describes any kind of yoga class involving asanas. A sun salutation, for example, is an important series of 12 asanas that begin many kinds of yoga classes.

Training under the hatha name, however, is usually gentler than others and more centered on breathing exercises, called pranayama. Poses are held for a few breaths and students usually move more slowly.

Hatha can be good for beginners who are looking to relax while improving flexibility and balance.

Another style, yin, pays even more attention to recovery by working to stretch the muscles’ connective tissue. Students hold poses for 5 minutes or more, permitting the body to settle into a pose rather than pushing it.

FILE - People do yoga poses on paddleboards at sunset at Olathe Lake on July 15, 2024, in Olathe, Kan. (AP Photo/Charlie Riedel)

The vinyasa/ashtanga styles

A more difficult, flowing form of yoga is known as vinyasa. It mixes movement with breath over a series of asanas. Some higher-level vinyasa classes move at a rate of one movement per breath.

In the United States, these classes are often called Flow or Power yoga. They can be good for people who are more athletic. Still, teachers suggest that even athletic students start with a beginner level.

“I wouldn’t really encourage them to start in a higher level vinyasa flow class because they’re not going to have the foundation to move safely through that,” said Anne Van Valkenburg, of Lanai, Hawaii. She has been training yoga teachers in a mix of methods for 18 years.

Ashtanga yoga is similar to vinyasa. However, ashtanga involves a set series of poses that students repeat day after day, often going at their own speed. As students get stronger and more skilled, they move up to a higher series with more difficult poses.

The Iyengar style

Iyengar style involves the same poses as vinyasa, but classes usually move at a slower pace. However, the poses are not necessarily easier. Iyengar yoga pays special attention to carefully moving or aligning parts of the body. Poses are held for longer and students often use supportive equipment during the exercise.

Iyengar is especially good for people recovering from injuries. It can also be a good fit for physically active people who want to get the basics of yoga before moving into different styles.

Find a good fit

These days, teachers often mix different yoga methods in a single class. And many classes are not named under any traditional method.

The AP suggests that if you are interested in starting to practice yoga, you should look for a beginner series. But if you cannot find one that is right, do not worry. Most teachers are happy to have beginners in their classes and will alter the training to meet the needs of students new to yoga.

Most of all, try a few classes until you find the method or teacher who is a good fit for you.

“I feel sad when someone tries yoga once or twice and they’re like, ‘Eh, I don’t like it,’” Van Valkenburg said, adding, “there’s just so much out there that you might be missing...”

I’m John Russell.

Albert Stumm reported on this story for the Associated Press. John Russell adapted it for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

relax - v. ผ่อนคลาย ทำให้หรือกลายเป็นตึงเครียดน้อยลง หรือกังวลน้อยลง

flexibility - n. ความยืดหยุ่น ความสามารถของข้อต่อและกล้ามเนื้อในการเคลื่อนไหวผ่านพิสัยการเคลื่อนที่

encourage - v. ส่งเสริม ทำให้ใครบางคนต้องการที่จะทำบางสิ่งบางอย่าง

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What is the original meaning of the word "yoga" from Sanskrit?

- A) Exercise
- B) Movement
- C) Union
- D) Health

2. According to the article, which of the following is NOT described as a way people perceive yoga?

- A) A series of difficult body movements
- B) An exercise focused on mindful breathing
- C) A form of competitive sport
- D) A spiritual exercise

3. What common element is involved in all kinds of yoga, regardless of style?

- A) Mindful breathing techniques
- B) Positions known as poses (asanas)
- C) The use of supportive equipment
- D) A focus on spiritual enlightenment

4. According to Tim Senesi, what is the "best" kind of yoga training for a beginner?

- A) The one that is gentler and slower-paced.
- B) The one that works for the individual.
- C) The one that focuses on difficult body movements.
- D) The one that leads to improved flexibility and balance.

5. What does the Sanskrit word "hatha" mean in the context of yoga?

- A) Union
- B) Flow

- C) Force
- D) Balance

6. Which characteristic typically describes hatha yoga training compared to other styles?

- A) It involves higher-level, fast-paced movements.
- B) It is usually gentler and focuses on breathing exercises.
- C) It requires holding poses for 5 minutes or more.
- D) It primarily targets athletic individuals for strength building.

7. For which type of beginner is hatha yoga particularly suitable?

- A) Those seeking a challenging, athletic workout.
- B) Those recovering from serious injuries.
- C) Those looking to relax while improving flexibility and balance.
- D) Those interested in competitive yoga forms.

8. What is a distinguishing feature of the yin yoga style?

- A) It involves rapid transitions between poses.
- B) It focuses on building core strength through vigorous movement.
- C) It emphasizes recovery by stretching connective tissue and holding poses for extended periods.
- D) It uses a set series of poses repeated daily.

9. How is vinyasa yoga generally described?

- A) A very slow-paced style focused on alignment.
- B) A difficult, flowing form that mixes movement with breath.
- C) A spiritual practice without physical poses.
- D) A style exclusively for injury recovery.

10. In the United States, what are some common alternative names for vinyasa yoga classes?

- A) Gentle Flow or Relaxation Yoga
- B) Power Flow or Recovery Yoga
- C) Flow or Power yoga
- D) Mindful Movement or Yin Flow

11. Why does Anne Van Valkenburg advise against beginners starting in a higher-level vinyasa flow class?

- A) They might not enjoy the fast pace.

- B) They could develop bad habits early on.
- C) They might not have the foundation to move safely.
- D) The classes are too expensive for beginners.

12. What distinguishes Ashtanga yoga from vinyasa, even though they are similar?

- A) Ashtanga typically involves gentler movements and longer holds.
- B) Ashtanga focuses heavily on spiritual enlightenment rather than physical poses.
- C) Ashtanga has a set series of poses that students repeat daily, often at their own speed.
- D) Ashtanga incorporates more supportive equipment during practice.

13. What is a key characteristic of Iyengar style yoga?

- A) It emphasizes rapid, flowing movements similar to vinyasa.
- B) It pays special attention to body alignment and often uses supportive equipment.
- C) It is designed for competitive athletes seeking strength and endurance.
- D) Poses are typically held for only a few breaths to keep the pace dynamic.

14. For whom is Iyengar yoga especially good?

- A) People who prefer extremely fast-paced and challenging workouts.
- B) Individuals recovering from injuries or active people wanting basics.
- C) Advanced practitioners looking to master difficult inversions.
- D) Those who want to primarily focus on meditation without physical poses.

15. What advice does the AP give to someone interested in starting yoga if they cannot find a suitable beginner series?

- A) They should try an advanced class to challenge themselves.
- B) They should give up and try a different form of exercise.
- C) They should not worry, as most teachers will alter training for new students.
- D) They should exclusively look for classes named under traditional methods.